October 7, 2026

The Editor-in-Chief
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Dear Editor,

We are pleased to submit our manuscript, *"The Price of Speed: Optimising Dark-Store Networks and Rider Assignment under Relaxed Delivery Promises in Indian Quick Commerce"*, for consideration as an original research article in *OPSEARCH*.

In January 2026 India's quick-commerce platforms withdrew their "10-minute delivery" claims after the Union Labour Ministry raised rider-safety concerns, and in August 2026 a Parliamentary Standing Committee recommended curbs on "unrealistic speed targets" without defining them. Our paper gives that debate a quantitative operations research answer for Bengaluru, India's most contested quick-commerce market.

The study makes three contributions that we believe suit *OPSEARCH*'s focus on operational research in practice and its Indian readership:

- a bibliometric review of 168 OR articles on last-mile and on-demand delivery (2015–2026), which shows that quick commerce, Indian settings and rider welfare are almost absent from the literature;
- an integrated, reproducible chain of classical OR models—coverage-constrained facility location, transportation, assignment and PERT—built entirely from public Indian data (WorldPop 2025, BBMP ward boundaries, OpenStreetMap and platform shareholder disclosures);
- policy-relevant findings: the delivery promise mainly determines *who* can be served, while rider speed determines cost; and promising 10 minutes only where an address is reachable at a safe speed serves 87% of residents within 10 minutes at about 4% higher cost than a uniform 15-minute network.

All data sources are public, and the code, processed data and screening log are openly available. In accordance with Springer Nature policy, the use of a generative AI assistant is documented in the Methods section; it is not listed as an author, and the authors take full responsibility for the content.

This manuscript is original, has not been published previously, and is not under consideration elsewhere. All authors have approved the manuscript and agree with its submission to *OPSEARCH*. There are no competing interests to declare and no funding to report.

Thank you for considering our work.

Yours sincerely,

Madhav Gupta
on behalf of all authors
[Institution]
[corresponding author e-mail]